fact, as an eyewitness describes it, the bemused ambassador may have had some trouble identifying his host.

Cries of ‘Badshah Salamat’ filled the air, writes Rafi al-din Ibrahim Shirazi, a Persian immigrant at the scene, but it was impossible to tell who they were hailing. ‘I looked to my left and right but did not find anyone having the appearance of a king. As I turned around, I saw standing there a young man of about twenty years.’ The young man had rested one hand on a friend’s shoulder, and tilted his head upon that hand – a casual, almost slack pose that communicated itself to his audience. ‘I could guess he was the king,’ writes the immigrant, appalled. ‘But the men continued to stand around rubbing shoulders with each other. No one observed the etiquette of showing respect to the king.’

Scandalized, Rafi asked bystanders what was going on, and was told that Akbar was ‘an exceedingly informal person’. How was it possible, in his unceremonious presence, to ‘observe etiquette’?[42]

In keeping with such informality about official business, on 16 May 1562, Akbar skipped ‘court day . . . in the royal hall’. The padishah felt no need to attend. This is how it had been with Bairam, too. The regent would hold a couple of meetings every week, with all the chiefs, and fill Akbar in afterwards. Now, it was Shamsuddin, his vakil; Munim Khan, his khan-khanan; and Shihabuddin, Maham Anaka’s representative, who sat with other, lesser lords, ‘transacting public business’, while Akbar remained upstairs.[43] It was a summer day and the padishah was fast asleep in the cool chambers of the harem. Afterwards, if an evening breeze stirred, he might have planned to fly a kite – as Rafi had once seen him do, running about the palace roof in a lungi, his head uncovered.[44]

He woke at a sudden clamour. What was going on? Akbar wrapped on his lungi,[45] walked out and leaned over the parapet to look into the courtyard below. There was Rafiq, an old retainer. What was going on?

Abul Fazl has Rafiq spell out an impressively coherent narrative of the chaos engulfing the palace. More likely, the old man could only point at the corpse in the courtyard and call out the urgent facts: Adham has killed your ataka!

This is what had happened: only moments ago, Adham Khan swaggered into the council meeting with his men. The lords of the council rose to greet